



based fintech company, launched Kiyaverse—supposedly India's first banking metaverse. Banks as well as non-banking finance companies (NBFCs) can use the platform to create their own in-branch experiences on the metaverse. Users can access the platform through multiple interfaces, including digital banking units, mobiles, laptops, VR headsets, and mixed reality (MR) environments. Through their virtual avatars, users can interact with a virtual relationship manager, and avail basic and value-added services like portfolio analysis, wealth management, co-lending, and corporate banking.

Kiya.ai will also offer various analytics based services to its partner banks and NBFCs. Future phases are likely to support central bank digital currencies (CBDCs) for transactions and interoperability with other metaverses. Open application programming interface (API) connectors with aggregators and gateways will eventually enable a banking super-app and marketplace.

They hope to give users a near real-world interaction experience with haptics-enabled headsets and using the 'Internet of Senses.' The Internet of Senses is a concept floated last year by Ericsson as part of its vision for 2030. It proposes the idea of a full sensory immersion in cyberspace, made possible by the low latency and high bandwidth of 5G.

The new-age collectibles

Movies and cricket are two undying passions in India. Digital collectibles, that is NFTs, are likely to do well in both these fields.



Users can tour a virtual facsimile of the INTERPOL General Secretariat headquarters in Lyon, France without any geographical or physical boundaries (Courtesy: INTERPOL)

A couple of months back, Singapore based Vistas Media Capital partnered with *Rocketry - The Nambi Effect* to introduce NFTs themed around the movie plot and scientific research on their metaverse space called the VistaVerse. It was a runaway success, with more than 10,000 NFTs being claimed.

Zee Entertainment Enterprises, the well-known media house, opened its Tech & Innovation centre in Bengaluru a couple of months ago. Among other things, the centre will focus on Zee's metaverse, the Zeeverse, which will offer numerous interesting NFTs from the movies, music, and shows that the company holds the license to. According to the company, viewers will also be able to meet their favourite stars through the Zeeverse.

Earlier this year, T-Series announced a partnership with Hefty Entertainment, a division of Hungama Digital Media, to drop NFTs that leverage its mega content library.

In October, cricketer Virat Kohli tweeted that he was super pumped to enter the metaverse exclusively with FanCraze. This means, his fans can now buy digital collectibles, such as the digital version of a signed bat or poster, or a valuable cricketing moment, directly licensed

from Kohli, and display them on their social media handles, trade them, and use them in various games.

Kohli joins a long list of Indian cricketers, including Rohit Sharma, Hardik Pandya, Suryakumar Yadav, Ravindra Jadeja, Shikhar Dhawan, Ravichandran Ashwin, Yuzvendra Chahal, and Shreyas Iyer, who have also partnered with FanCraze to drop digital collectibles and build a direct connect with their

fans. "We view marquee athletes as artists who create their art on the field of play," said FanCraze CEO Anshum Bhambri, in a media report.

It does not stop with buying NFTs but leads to more ways of engagement. For example, fans may be able to get on a Zoom call with a player whose collectibles they own, go to a nets session with them, interview them, or have access to signed merchandise.

A new crime scene for INTERPOL

At the 90th INTERPOL General Assembly held in New Delhi in October, the global police organisation unveiled its new metaverse, designed specifically for law enforcement. Registered users can tour a virtual replica of INTERPOL's headquarters, interact with other officers via their avatars, and even take immersive training courses. During the demo, experts delivered a training on travel document verification and passenger screening using INTERPOL capabilities in a metaverse classroom. Students were then teleported to an airport where they were able to practically try out these skills at a virtual border point.

Law enforcers from around